

Word family: **underestimate / underestimates / underestimated / underestimating / underestimation**

Base word: underestimate

Part of speech: mainly **verb**, also **noun**

Related forms:

* **underestimate** (v.) — 低估；估計不足

* **underestimate** (n.) — 過低的估計

* **underestimated** (adj./participle) — 被低估的

* **underestimating** (gerund/participle) — 低估

* **underestimation** (n.) — 低估；估計不足

* **underestimate the time / cost / difficulty**

* **underestimate someone**

* **underestimate the importance / impact / risk**

* **seriously / badly / greatly underestimate**

* **don't underestimate...**

Meaning in this passage

> The turning point came after I nearly missed an important assignment because I had
underestimated how long it would take.

Here, **underestimated** means:

**estimated that the assignment would take less time than it actually needed — 低估；估少了

The speaker expected the assignment to take less time than it really did, so they nearly missed the deadline.

**中文翻譯： **

我差點錯過一份很重要的作業，因為我**低估了它所需要的時間**。

So here:

underestimate how long something will take = 以為所需時間比實際所需時間短

1. **underestimate an amount / quantity — 低估數量；估少**

This is the broad numerical sense behind the passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> I **underestimated how long the assignment would take**.

我**低估了這份作業所需的時間**。

Practice 2

> We **underestimated the number of people** who would attend.

我們**低估了出席人數**。

Practice 3

> I badly **underestimated the amount of work involved**.

我嚴重**低估了所涉及的工作量**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****underestimate = 對數量、程度或規模作出的估計比實際情況低****

2. **underestimate how long something will take — 低估所需時間**

This is the exact pattern in your passage.

Practice 1

> She **underestimated how long the journey would take**.

她**低估了旅程所需的時間**。

Practice 2

> People often **underestimate how long revision takes**.

人們經常**低估溫習所需的時間**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****underestimate how long X will take = 認為完成 X 所需的時間比實際時間短****

3. **underestimate the time needed / required — 低估所需時間**

Practice 1

> I **underestimated the time needed** to finish the report.

我**低估了完成報告所需要的時間**。

Practice 2

> They had **underestimated the time required** for repairs.

他們**低估了維修所需時間**。

MCQ-ready definition:

underestimate the time needed = 對完成某事所需時間作出過低估計

4. **underestimate the cost — 低估成本 / 費用**

Practice 1

> We **underestimated the cost** of the renovation.

我們**低估了翻新工程的成本**。

Practice 2

> The original budget **underestimated the total cost**.

原本的預算**低估了總成本**。

MCQ-ready definition:

underestimate the cost = 估計的費用低於實際費用

5. **underestimate the difficulty — 低估難度**

Practice 1

> I completely **underestimated the difficulty of the exam**.

我完全**低估了考試的難度**。

Practice 2

> Don't **underestimate how difficult the task is**.

不要**低估這項任務的難度**。

MCQ-ready definition:

underestimate difficulty = 認為某件事比實際更容易

6. **underestimate the scale / size — 低估規模**

Practice 1

> They **underestimated the scale of the problem**.

他們**低估了問題的規模**。

Practice 2

> We had **underestimated the size of the audience**.

我們**低估了觀眾人數 / 規模**。

MCQ-ready definition:

underestimate the scale/size = 認為某件事的規模比實際小

7. **underestimate the seriousness / severity — 低估嚴重程度**

Practice 1

> At first, we **underestimated the seriousness of the situation**.

起初，我們**低估了情況的嚴重性**。

Practice 2

> He had **underestimated the severity of the damage**.

他**低估了損害的嚴重程度**。

MCQ-ready definition:

underestimate seriousness/severity = 認為問題沒有實際上那麼嚴重

8. **underestimate the risk — 低估風險**

Practice 1

> Never **underestimate the risk** of rushing important work.

不要**低估匆忙處理重要工作的風險**。

Practice 2

> Investors had **underestimated the risks involved**.

投資者**低估了當中的風險**。

MCQ-ready definition:

underestimate risk = 認為出現負面結果的可能性或危險程度比實際低

9. **underestimate the impact / effect — 低估影響**

Practice 1

> I **underestimated the impact** that poor sleep had on my concentration.

我**低估了睡眠不足對專注力的影響**。

Practice 2

> Don't **underestimate the effect** of small habits.

不要**低估小習慣帶來的影響**。

MCQ-ready definition:

underestimate impact/effect = 認為某事造成的影響比實際小

10. **underestimate the importance / value of something — 低估重要性 / 價值**

Practice 1

> People often **underestimate the importance of preparation**.

人們經常**低估準備的重要性**。

Practice 2

> Don't **underestimate the value of a good routine**.

不要**低估良好日常習慣的價值**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****underestimate importance/value = 認為某物的重要程度或價值低於實際情況****

11. **underestimate someone — 低估某人的能力**

A major distinct branch.

Practice 1

> His opponents **underestimated him**.

他的對手**低估了他**。

Practice 2

> Don't **underestimate her** just because she is quiet.

不要因為她安靜就**低估她的能力**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****underestimate someone = 認為某人的能力、力量或潛力比實際低****

12. **underestimate someone's ability — 低估某人的能力**

Practice 1

> The teacher had **underestimated his ability**.

老師曾經**低估他的能力**。

Practice 2

> I think we **underestimated what she was capable of**.

我覺得我們**低估了她的能力**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****underestimate someone's ability = 認為某人的能力比實際差或有限****

13. ****underestimate someone's strength — 低估某人的實力 / 力量****

Practice 1

> The team ****underestimated their opponents' strength****.

球隊**低估了對手的實力**。

Practice 2

> Never ****underestimate your own strength****.

不要**低估自己的力量 / 能力**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****underestimate strength = 對某人的力量、實力或承受能力估計過低****

14. ****underestimate someone's potential — 低估某人的潛力****

Practice 1

> Don't ****underestimate a child's potential****.

不要**低估孩子的潛力**。

Practice 2

> His managers initially ****underestimated his potential****.

他的經理最初**低估了他的潛力**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****underestimate potential = 認為某人將來能做到的事情比實際可能達到的少****

15. ****don't underestimate... — 不要小看.....****

A very common warning structure.

Practice 1

> ****Don't underestimate**** how much preparation you need.

****不要低估****你需要做多少準備。

Practice 2

> ****Don't underestimate**** the power of a sincere apology.

****不要小看****真誠道歉的力量。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****don't underestimate X = 提醒別人不要把 X 看得太弱、太小、太容易或不重要****

16. ****seriously / badly / greatly underestimate — 嚴重低估****

Practice 1

> I ****seriously underestimated**** the workload.

我****嚴重低估了**工作量******。

Practice 2

> They had ****greatly underestimated**** demand.

他們****大幅低估了**需求******。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****seriously/badly/greatly underestimate = 實際情況與原來過低估計之間有很大差距****

17. ****underestimated (被低估的) — 被低估的****

Practice 1

> She is an ****underestimated player****.

她是一名**實力被低估的球員**。

Practice 2

> Sleep is an **underestimated part of productivity**.

睡眠是生產力中一個**經常被低估的重要部分**。

MCQ-ready definition:

underestimated = 實際價值、能力或重要性比人們普遍認為的高

18. **an underestimated problem / factor — 被低估的問題 / 因素**

Practice 1

> Fatigue is an **underestimated factor** in poor decision-making.

疲勞是導致錯誤決策的一個**經常被低估的因素**。

Practice 2

> Time pressure is often an **underestimated problem**.

時間壓力往往是一個**被低估的問題**。

MCQ-ready definition:

underestimated X = X 的重要性或嚴重程度通常沒有得到足夠重視

19. **underestimate (noun : 過低估計) — 過低的估計**

The verb is much more common, but the noun is established.

Practice 1

> The original figure was a serious **underestimate**.

最初那個數字是一個嚴重的**低估**。

Practice 2

> Ten hours turned out to be an **underestimate**.

事實證明，十小時這個估計**偏低**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****an underestimate = 比實際數量、成本、時間或程度低的估計****

20. ****underestimation — 低估；估計不足****

Practice 1

> The delay resulted from an ****underestimation of the workload****.

延誤是由於****低估工作量****所造成的。

Practice 2

> Their ****underestimation of the costs**** created problems later.

他們對成本的****低估****後來造成了問題。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****underestimation = 對數量、程度、能力或重要性估計過低的行為或結果****

21. ****underestimation of time — 對時間估計不足****

Practice 1

> Poor planning often involves an ****underestimation of time requirements****.

規劃不善通常涉及****低估所需時間****。

Practice 2

> The ****underestimation of travel time**** made us late.

對旅程時間的****估計不足****令我們遲到。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****underestimation of time = 對實際需要多少時間作出偏低估計****

Important distinction 1: ****underestimate vs estimate****

estimate

make an approximate calculation or judgment.

underestimate

your estimate is **too low**.

> I estimated it would take three hours.

> 我估計要三小時。

> I underestimated it—it took six.

> 我**低估了**，結果要六小時。

Important distinction 2: **underestimate vs overestimate**

Exact opposites.

underestimate

estimate too low.

overestimate

estimate too high.

> I thought it would take one hour, but it took three.

> → I **underestimated** the time.

> I thought it would take five hours, but it took two.

> → I **overestimated** the time.

Important distinction 3: **underestimate vs miscalculate**

underestimate

specifically too low.

miscalculate

calculate incorrectly in either direction.

So every numerical underestimate is a kind of incorrect estimate, but a miscalculation is not necessarily an underestimate.

Important distinction 4: ****underestimate vs misunderstand****

****underestimate****

judge degree, size, ability, importance, etc. too low.

****misunderstand****

understand the meaning or situation incorrectly.

> underestimate the difficulty

> 低估難度

> misunderstand the instructions

> 誤解指示

Important distinction 5: ****underestimate vs overlook****

****underestimate****

you recognize something exists, but judge it as less important/strong than it really is.

****overlook****

you fail to notice or consider it.

> We underestimated the risk.

> 我們知道有風險，但****低估了它****。

> We overlooked the risk.

> 我們****沒有注意到 / 忽略了風險****。

Excellent distinction.

Important distinction 6: ****underestimate vs undervalue****

underestimate

judge amount, ability, importance, difficulty, etc. too low.

undervalue

judge monetary or broader worth too low.

> underestimate her ability

> 低估她的能力

> undervalue her contribution

> 低估她的貢獻價值

There is overlap in figurative contexts, but **undervalue** strongly emphasizes **worth/value**.

Important distinction 7: **underestimate vs understate**

underestimate

make an internal/external estimate that is too low.

understate

describe or report something as less important/serious/large than it really is.

> We underestimated the cost.

> 我們估少了成本。

> The report understated the cost.

> 報告把成本**說得比實際低**。

Important distinction 8: **underestimate someone vs look down on someone**

underestimate someone

think they are less capable than they actually are.

look down on someone

consider them socially/personally inferior.

You can underestimate someone without disrespecting them personally.

Important distinction 9: ****underestimate someone vs doubt someone****

****doubt****

be uncertain they can succeed.

****underestimate****

judge their actual ability too low.

Someone can doubt another person and turn out to be right; ****underestimate**** implies the judgment was too low.

Important distinction 10: ****underestimate the time vs run out of time****

These describe different stages.

****underestimate the time****

planning error:

> I thought it would take less time.

****run out of time****

result:

> there was no time left.

Your passage shows the first leading toward the second.

Important distinction 11: ****underestimate how long vs underestimate how much time****

Both are natural:

> underestimate ****how long it would take****

> underestimate ****how much time it would take****

The first is especially natural and concise.

Important distinction 12: **underestimate + noun vs underestimate + wh-clause**

Noun:

> underestimate the difficulty

Clause:

> underestimate how difficult it would be

Both express the same broad idea, but the clause often gives richer information.

Important distinction 13: **underestimate has an evaluative implication**

If you say:

> I underestimated the task.

you normally mean your original judgment was **too low compared with reality**.

So unlike plain **estimate**, the word already tells us that the estimate was inaccurate in a particular direction.

Family-extension note

Underestimate has one very stable semantic core:

judge something as less, smaller, easier, weaker, cheaper, shorter, or less important than it really is

That branches into:

1. **quantity**

* underestimate numbers

* underestimate demand

2. **time/cost**

- * underestimate how long
- * underestimate cost

3. **difficulty/scale**

- * underestimate difficulty
- * underestimate scale

4. **risk/impact**

- * underestimate risk
- * underestimate impact

5. **importance/value**

- * underestimate importance

6. **people**

- * underestimate someone's ability
- * underestimate someone's potential

7. **noun family**

- * an underestimate
- * underestimation

Unlike some highly polysemous words, **underestimate** is semantically very coherent. Its teaching value comes from the wide range of things that can be judged **too low**, plus its contrasts with **overestimate, overlook, undervalue,** and **understate**.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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underestimate	低估	judge too low	
underestimate how long	低估所需時間	time	
underestimate time needed	低估所需時間	planning	
underestimate cost	低估成本	money	
underestimate difficulty	低估難度	challenge	
underestimate scale	低估規模	size	
underestimate seriousness	低估嚴重性	severity	

underestimate risk	低估風險	danger	
underestimate impact	低估影響	effect	
underestimate importance	低估重要性	significance	
underestimate someone	低估某人	ability	
underestimate someone's strength	低估某人實力	strength	
underestimate potential	低估潛力	future ability	
don't underestimate X	不要小看 X	warning	
seriously underestimate	嚴重低估	large error	
underestimated	被低估的	judged too low	
an underestimate	過低的估計	noun result	
underestimation	低估；估計不足	process/state	

For your original sentence

> The turning point came after I nearly missed an important assignment because I had
 underestimated how long it would take.

Here:

underestimated how long it would take = 我原本以為這份作業很快便能完成，但實際所需時間遠比我預計的長

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 真正的轉捩點，是有一次我差點錯過一份很重要的作業，因為我**低估了它所需要的時間**。

The cleanest contrast is:

- > **estimate** = 作出估計
- > **underestimate** = **估得太低 / 太少**
- > **overestimate** = **估得太高 / 太多**

In this passage, the speaker's mistake was specifically a **planning error**:

actual time needed > time they expected

That misjudgment is exactly what **underestimate** captures.